Structuring Practice Bank

Consulting Technical Curriculum companion to C02. 10 prompts with model issue trees.

For each prompt, take up to 60 seconds, build a MECE issue tree on paper, then compare to the model structure. The model is one strong structure, not the only one. Aim for three or four branches with no overlaps and no gaps, and lead with a hypothesis about which branch holds the answer.

Prompt 1

A national retailer's profit fell 20% last year. Structure the problem.

MODEL STRUCTURE

- Revenue: price (discounting, mix) and volume (traffic, conversion, basket), by channel and region
- Cost: variable (COGS, store labor, logistics) and fixed (rent, overhead)
- Internal vs external: is the whole sector down, or only this retailer
- First hypothesis: name the branch you suspect and test it

Prompt 2

Should a coffee chain enter a new country? Structure it.

MODEL STRUCTURE

- Market: size, growth, willingness to pay, barriers
- Competition: incumbents, their share, likely response
- Company fit: brand travel, supply chain, right to win
- Entry mode: build, buy, or partner, plus investment and timing

Prompt 3

Should a consumer brand launch a new product? Structure it.

MODEL STRUCTURE

- Demand: market size, customer need, growth
- Economics: price, contribution margin, breakeven volume
- Cannibalization: how much steals from our own products
- Fit and net: capability to make and sell, net profit after cannibalization

Prompt 4

Should Company A acquire Company B? Structure it.

MODEL STRUCTURE

- Rationale: why buy, and build vs buy vs partner
- Target: market, growth, quality of the business
- Synergies: cost (reliable) and revenue (optimistic), net of cost to achieve
- Risk and price: integration risk, then go or no-go with a price

Prompt 5

How should we price a new differentiated device? Structure it.

MODEL STRUCTURE

- Floor: variable cost plus minimum margin
- Reference: what competitors charge
- Ceiling: customer-perceived value
- Position and volume: place in the band by differentiation, check total profit

Prompt 6

A software firm's revenue dropped 15% in a quarter. Structure it.

MODEL STRUCTURE

- Price vs volume: did revenue per customer fall or did customers leave
- Segment: by product line, customer size, geography, new vs renewal
- Internal vs external: competitor move, product issue, or market shift
- Hypothesis: state the most likely cause and the data that tests it

Prompt 7

A retailer's delivery costs are too high. Structure it.

MODEL STRUCTURE

- Size the cost base: last-mile labor, fuel and fleet, failed deliveries, packaging
- Find the biggest and most wasteful line first
- Levers: route optimization, first-attempt success, consolidation, automation
- Constraint: protect the service levels customers actually pay for

Prompt 8

A mature packaged-food brand has flat domestic sales. How should it grow?

MODEL STRUCTURE

- Existing product, existing market: frequency, basket, price
- Existing product, new market: new geographies or segments
- New product, existing market: cross-sell to the loyal base
- Sequence by risk; new product in a new market is the last resort

Prompt 9

A hospital wants to cut emergency room wait times. Structure it.

MODEL STRUCTURE

- Map the flow: check-in, triage, doctor, tests, treatment, discharge
- Find the bottleneck: where does the queue form
- Relieve it: capacity at the constraint, faster test turnaround, fast-track lane

- Rebalance: re-check where the new queue forms

Prompt 10

Should a regional airline add a new route? Structure it.

MODEL STRUCTURE

- Demand: route traffic, business vs leisure mix, seasonality
- Economics: load factor, fare, cost per available seat mile, breakeven load
- Competition: incumbents on the route and likely fare response
- Fit: fleet, slots, crew, and network effects with existing routes